Country Profile: Australia

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 9
- Plurality religion: Protestantism; Roman Catholicism since late 2010s
- Official language: None
- Official religion: None
- Core group: White Australians

Historical Background

The Commonwealth of Australia is a federal state and constitutional monarchy, with the monarch of the United Kingdom and the Commonwealth realms remaining the head of state. It was established in 1901, when the British self-governing colonies of New South Wales, Western Australia, South Australia, Queensland, Victoria, and Tasmania agreed to form a united federal polity and subsequently increased their autonomy from the United Kingdom. Although the territory of present-day Australia has been home to diverse Indigenous peoples for tens of thousands of years, the modern state and its demographic composition have been shaped by European settlement which began in the late 18th century.

Groups

- **Aboriginal Peoples** form an Indigenous racialized group in Australia, comprising between 1% and 3% of its population.[1] Of the many languages spoken by Indigenous communities in the country, Kriol, Pitjantjatjara and Djambarrpuyngu are the most widely used.[2] The group is predominantly Christian, a legacy of colonial conversion, with the overwhelming majority adhering to the Roman Catholic faith, although a small minority continue to practice its ancestral

[1] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2006.
[2] Ethnologue, 2025.

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Indigenous belief system.[3] A victim of British colonialization, the group's pursuit of greater self-determination pre-dates 1945.[4]

- **Torres Strait Islanders** have historically inhabited the islands north of Queensland and more recently also migrated to mainland Australia.[5] This Indigenous racialized group amounts to less than 1% of the state's permanent population.[6] The group largely speaks Torres Strait Creole but also Kala Lagaw Ya and Meriam Mir. However, their ancestral languages are currently vulnerable, as they mostly speak English.[7] A significant portion of the population follows the Anglican branch of Christianity, with a slightly smaller share identifying with other Protestant denominations. A comparable proportion consider themselves non-religious. Among the Torres Strait Islanders, the Tagai belief system has historically formed the cornerstone of spiritual life.[8] When James Akee formed the Torres United Party in 1976, Torres Strait Islanders actively began to demand greater autonomy.[9]
- **White Australians** are the descendants of European settlers that arrived in Australia before but also during the 20th century.[10] Today forming a distinct racialized group, they make up approximately 92% of the population,[11] the largest and politically dominant ethnic segment of Australia's population. They are associated with the English language,[12] the principal language of the country, and predominantly follow the Catholic (and to a lesser extent Anglican) faiths with a significant share of non-religious people.[13] For a considerable part of Australia's independent history, the "White Australia Policy" restricted Asian immigration and promoted Australia as a "white" country, reinforcing the group's dominant position.

[3] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017; State Library NSW, 2025.
[4] Sambanis, Germann, and Schädel, 2018.
[5] Minority Rights Group, 2024.
[6] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2016.
[7] Ethnologue, 2025.
[8] Queensland Curriculum & Assessment Authority, 2018.
[9] Sambanis, Germann, and Schädel, 2018.
[10] Minority Rights Group, 2024.
[11] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2016; EPR, 2021; CIA Factbook, 2025.
[12] Ethnologue, 2025.
[13] Bormann, Cederman, and Vogt, 2017.

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- **Chinese** began arriving in Australia in the mid-nineteenth century, but the "White Australia Policy" halted an additional inflow of members of the group between its adoption in 1901 and its abandonment in 1958.[14] In the 21st century, the population of this racialized group began rising, and it now comprises almost 4% of the state's population.[15] Group members speak different variants of the Chinese macrolanguage, in particular Mandarin, Yue and Min nan.[16] More than half of Australia's Chinese population is non-religious, with smaller fragments practicing Buddhism and Catholicism.[17]
- **Vietnamese** arrived in large numbers in Australia as refugees following the take-over of the North Vietnamese communist government in 1975.[18] They now form a racialized group of almost 1% of the state's population.[19] While the group as a whole is associated with the Vietnamese language,[20] it is diverse in religious terms, with approximately half of its members practicing Buddhism, one-fifth observing Roman Catholicism, and another one-fourth being non-religious.[21]
- **Filipinos** have been present as a racialized group in Australia since 1973, when they began arriving as refugees following the declaration of martial law in the Philippines. Subsequently, members of this group have been admitted via Family Reunion Programs.[22] Numbering less than 1% of the Australian population,[23] they speak Tagalog and Cebuano languages[24] and largely follow Roman Catholicism, with only a small group practicing Protestantism.
- **South Asians** are a nested racialized group of **Indians** and **Sri Lankans**. The group first became socially visible in Australia in the 1960s following the relaxation of the "White Australia Policy" and a subsequent influx of skilled professionals from India. It further increased in size with the arrival of refugees fleeing the Sri Lankan

[14] Minority Rights Group, 2024; National Archives of Australia, 1901.
[15] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2016.
[16] Ethnologue, 2024.
[17] Tao and Stapleton, 2018.
[18] Refugee Council of Australia, 2023.
[19] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2016.
[20] Ethnologue, 2025.
[21] Joshua Project, 2025.
[22] Australian Government, 2016f.
[23] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2016.
[24] Ethnologue, 2025; Australian Government, 2016f.

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civil war during the 1980s.[25] Jointly, this group constitutes around 2.4% of Australia's inhabitants.[26] Hindi is the language of common ancestry for Indians, while Tamil is the native language of Sri Lankans.[27] The group is religiously diverse. Among Indians, Hinduism is the most widely practiced faith, followed by smaller proportions adhering to Sikhism and Roman Catholicism. In the case of Sri Lankans, Buddhism is the predominant religion, with notable segments identifying as Catholics or Hindus.[28]

- **Arabs** are a small nested racialized group making up 0.8% of Australia's population,[29] formed from immigrants from the Middle East and North Africa, particularly **Lebanese**, **Egyptians** and **Iraqis**. The presence of the group in Australia pre-dates 1945 and even Australian independence, with notable immigration from Lebanon taking place in the 1890s. Several waves of inflow from each of these countries followed over the course of the 20th century, partly driven by unrest in the region.[30] Members of this group speak Lebanese, Egyptian, and Mesopotamian Arabic as variants of the Arabic macro-language[31] and are characterized by notable religious diversity. Among the Lebanese, Islam is the plurality religion, followed by Roman Catholicism and Greek Orthodoxy. Egyptians are mostly Coptic Orthodox, followed by Roman Catholic and Muslims. Among Iraqis, Muslims form the most widespread religious group, though there are also notable numbers of Catholics and Syrian Orthodox Christians.[32] Although Arabs are present in all states, as per the 2016 census, most live relatively concentrated in New South Wales.[33]
- **Greeks** are already noted as present as a racialized group in Australia by the 1901 census, but the group increased notably in number in the 1960s after the Australian government started offering assisted passage in 1952.[34] The group comprised up to 1.8% of Australia's population in the early 2000s, but today

[25] High Commission of India, 2018; Australian Government, 2016c; Museum Victoria, 2017.
[26] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2016.
[27] Ethnologue, 2025.
[28] Australian Government, 2016g.
[29] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2016.
[30] Australian Government, 2016a.
[31] Ethnologue, 2025.
[32] Australian Government, 2016d.
[33] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2016.
[34] Australian Government, 2016b.

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official statistics suggest that they amounted to 0.4% of the country's population in the 2010s.[35] Although the group is associated with the Greek language,[36] most of its members speak English.[37] Greek Orthodoxy remains the dominant religion among Greeks, with only a small fraction declaring to be non-religious.[38]

State Profile

Official Language

Although Australia has never enacted a federal or constitutional law naming an "official" language, English functions as the nation's de facto official and national tongue—rooted in colonial governance and reinforced through education and public administration.

Official Religion

Australia does not have a state religion. This is explicitly stipulated in Chapter V of the 1901 Constitution: "The Commonwealth shall not make any law for establishing any religion."[39]

Education Policies

Australia's general education system is overseen by state and territory governments, with compulsory schooling typically beginning at age 5 or 6 and continuing until age 15 to 17, depending on local regulations. Education begins with non-compulsory kindergarten, followed by primary education, which spans approximately six to seven years. Secondary education consists of junior and senior levels. Both public and private schools, including religious institutions, follow standardized government curricula.[40] For a long time, the Australian public education system **segregated** Indigenous groups from the majority population, with school principals in New South Wales, for instance, being allowed to exclude Aboriginal students until 1972.[41] These children, many of whom were of mixed ancestry, were separated from their parents, denied knowledge of their cultural identity, language, and traditions, and raised in institutions designed to assimilate them into white

[35] Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2006; Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2006.
[36] Tamis, 1993.
[37] Ethnologue, 2025.
[38] Joshua Project, 2025.
[39] Act of the British Parliament, to constitute the Commonwealth of Australia, 1901.
[40] Scholarlo, 2025.
[41] Burridge and Chodkiewicz, 2012.

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society. These policies were reversed in the 1970s, and equal access to primary and secondary education was incrementally facilitated for previously segregated groups.

Affirmative action policies have been in place since 2003 to support Indigenous groups' access to higher education, as set out in the 2003 Higher Education Support Act. In this vein, in 2017, for instance, the Indigenous Students Support Program and the Indigenous Commonwealth Scholarship were put in place.[42]

Language Education Policies

English has been, and continues to be, used as the primary language of instruction in the Australian public education system.[43] In the Northern Territory, Aboriginal languages and **Torres Strait Creole** were introduced as languages of instruction in 1973 in public primary schools in a broader attempt by the federal government to further the use of Indigenous languages.[44] They were later incorporated into the Australian curriculum through the First Language Learner Pathway (L1). Likewise, remote schools have offered **Kriol**, **Pitjantjatjara**, **Djambarrpuyngu**, **Meriam Mir**, and **Kala Lagaw Ya** as languages of instruction alongside English since 1973, and all six states have provided them as optional language classes since 1989, following the adoption of the National Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Education Policy.

A series of other languages, associated with different migrant groups, have also found recognition in the Australian education system. Among immigrant-community languages, **Greek** became the first non-English language of instruction in Victoria when Lalor North Primary School launched its Greek-English immersion program in 1977; Greek entered other primary-school language classes in 1987 and secondary classes in 1977.[45]

Programs using **Mandarin** as a language of instruction began in 1984 in bilingual schools in the ACT and Victoria. Mandarin language classes were also offered to primary school students that year and extended to secondary school language classes by 1987.[46] **Vietnamese** immersion as a language of instruction commenced in 1997, while Vietnamese language classes have been offered since 1987.[47] **Standard Arabic** first

[42] Australian Government, 2025.
[43] Leclerc, 2024.
[44] Nicholls, 2005.
[45] Lalor North Primary School, 2025.
[46] Mawson Primary School, 2025; Abbotsford Primary School, 2020.
[47] Henriques-Gomes, 2020.

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appeared among officially recognized language classes in 1991 as a part of the national literacy policy.[48]

Tagalog—known as Filipino in Australia—and **Tamil** have been used in secondary schools since 2012 and have been taught in primary schools since 2019.[49] Finally, **Hindi** instruction has been offered in public primary schools since 2012 and secondary schools since 2015.[50]

Religious Education Policies

Section 17 of the Public Instruction Act of 1880 permitted Special Religious Instruction to be provided by visiting clergymen or other accredited religious teachers of their persuasion.[51] Since then, Christian denominations—Catholicism, Protestantism, and the Anglican faith—have been offered as optional classes in public schools. The New South Wales Education Act of 1990 later introduced a formal basis for the teaching of minority religions, also in the form of optional classes, in public schools.[52]

Bans and Restrictions

Aboriginal Peoples and Torres Strait Islanders

From the moment of British colonization until the broader policy shifts of the 1970s, Australia's Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander languages were systematically suppressed in favor of English. Assimilationist government and church policies banned or discouraged the public use of Indigenous languages, forced children into English-only hostels and missions, and regarded attempts to maintain or promote these languages with suspicion and outright hostility.[53] Only from the late 1960s and early 1970s—spurred by emerging Indigenous rights movements and changing federal attitudes—did these prohibitionist practices begin to be dismantled, marking the end of nearly two centuries of official language repression.[54]

[48] Commonwealth of Australia, 1991.
[49] NSW Education Standards Authority, 2023.
[50] Victorian Department of Education and Training.
[51] Catholic Archdiocese of Sydney, 2023.
[52] Gross and Rutland, 2021.
[53] Ozolins, 1988.
[54] Australian Human Rights Commission, 2009, 58.

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Demographic Engineering and Violence

State-Based Violence

Violence against **Aboriginal Peoples** and **Torres Strait Islanders** occurred mainly before 1945.[55] Since then, no campaigns of mass state-based violence took place

Forced Relocations/Segregation

Aboriginal Peoples and Torres Strait Islanders

From 1927 until 1954, Indigenous peoples were legally barred from entering the metropolitan "Prohibited Area" of Perth without a special permit, or "native pass", under the Aborigines Act 1905; failure to produce this pass could result in fines or imprisonment, effectively controlling Indigenous movement within what was deemed "white" city space.[56]

Cultural Elimination

The Stolen Generations (1910–1970) in Australia represent a case of cultural elimination, as **Aboriginal** and **Torres Strait Islander** children were forcibly removed from their families under assimilation policies sanctioned by state laws. Legislation such as the Aboriginal Protection Acts (Victoria, 1869; New South Wales, 1909; Queensland, 1897; Western Australia, 1905) and the Aboriginals Ordinance 1918 (Northern Territory) granted government officials the authority to separate Indigenous children from their communities. These policies aimed to systematically erase Indigenous cultural identity by prohibiting the practice of traditional customs, languages, and governance while encouraging European assimilation.[57]

Constitutions and Laws

The first constitution in force for Australia since 1945 was adopted in 1901. The constitutional text does not establish an official language. Universal freedom of religion is recognized and, although the state is not explicitly established as secular and the separation between state and church is not positively included as a principle of state organization, the constitution mandates that "[t]he Commonwealth shall not make any

[55] Dudgeon et al., 2014.
[56] Carmody, 2019; Wynne, 2025.
[57] O'Loughlin, 2022.

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law for establishing any religion."[58] Mentions of ethnic identities are largely absent from the constitutional text. Only Aboriginal People are mentioned, in a notably negative way, with Art. 127 holding that "[i]n reckoning the numbers of people of the Commonwealth [...], aboriginal natives shall not be counted."[59] This was rectified by a constitutional amendment in 1967. Since then, no ethnic identities are explicitly referred to in the text. Provisions on language and religion remained unchanged.

Citizenship Laws

For a large part of its independent history, Australia granted access to citizenship on grounds of being born in Australian territory, following in the *ius soli* principle. This was changed in 1986 through revision of the citizenship regime. Since then, citizenship at birth is granted only to children of Australian citizens or permanent residents, with all others being given access to citizenship only after 10 years of ordinary residence in Australia.[60]

With the adoption of the Immigration Restriction Act and the Naturalization Act 1920, the "White Australia Policy" was put in place, effectively excluding all groups that were not read as white Europeans from accessing Australian citizenship. In 1957, this policy was loosened, allowing for the naturalization of non-Europeans after 15 years of legal residence in Australia. This waiting period was reduced to 5 years in 1966, with remaining discriminatory differentiation between Europeans and non-Europeans abolished in 1972.[61]

At the same time, preferential access to citizenship has been granted to British subjects, allowing them to become Australian citizens through registration—a process similar to, but simpler than naturalization. Special provisions have also been established for Papua New Guineans, with the Australian Citizenship Act of 2007 introducing particular naturalization rules for individuals born in Papua before 1975, i.e., Papua New Guinean independence, to an Australian citizen parent born in Australia.[62]

[58] Act of the British Parliament, to constitute the Commonwealth of Australia, 1901, Art. 116.
[59] Act of the British Parliament, to constitute the Commonwealth of Australia, 1901, Art. 127.
[60] Thwaites, 2017.
[61] Thwaites, 2017; Jordens, 1999.
[62] Thwaites, 2017.

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National Anthem(s)

The Australian national anthem, "Advance Australia Fair," was adopted in 1984, and is available officially in the English language only. References to national territory, such as the country's "golden soil" feature prominently in the text. Furthermore, ambiguous references to nationhood, not clearly associated with a particular group, can be identified. Effective January 1, 2021, the line "for we are young and free," alluding to Australia as a "young" nation from the perspective of British colonists, was changed to "for we are one and free" in an effort to make the text more inclusive to the state's Indigenous population.[63]

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[63] Nationalanthems.info, 2025.

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